47TH ANNIVERSARY

THE BEST OF INDIA

CLASSICAL DANCERS



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The Dashavatara of Dance

While the aesthetic core of Indian classical dance has evolved over at least two millennia, the past century has been critical in shaping the structure and substance of the various forms we know today. Who were those 10—the dashavatara—who helped redefine nritya? Whose dancing footsteps turned the very path of India's cultural history? India's ace dance critic-historian offers his selection, with documentary evidence from the famed Mohan Khokar Dance Collection (MKDC), now donated to the Indira Gandhi National Centre for the Arts (IGNCA).



Uday Shankar

(1900-1977)

For India, he is the father of what's today called contemporary dance. Uday Shankar is credited with creating a non-classical but Indian dance vocabulary as early as the 1930s—after a brief excursion to western forms during his stint with ballerina Anna Pavlova's troupe. He did not debunk classical forms but simplified dance languages that were dependent on regional or classical texts. He honed his style in the lap of the Himalayas—in Almora, to be precise—and trained many before shifting to Chennai to make *Kalpana* (1948), a dance-themed film shot over seven years. His final years were spent in Calcutta, where he produced his swansong: the multi-format *Shankarscope*. His style was carried forward by disciples Sachin Shankar, Narendra Sharma and Mamata Shankar.

GETTY IMAGES



T. Balasaraswati

(1918-1984)

Born to a hereditary Devadasi family, with vocalist Veena Dhanammal as matriarch, T. Balasaraswati was the last spokesperson of the temple form–codified as a court style in Tanjore (the 'T' in her name). Her family had a whole gallery of top-notch musicians, and her style too was especially attuned to music. Shunned initially by Madras's caste-ridden sabhas, she was helped by lawyer-activist E. Krishna Iyer, The Music Academy head V. Raghavan, and then SNA head Mohan Khokar. In the US, the Scripps family were her patrons. Once the West feted her, and she regaled audiences from Japan to London, India followed. But her Bharatanatyam 'bani' ended with her.